



Marco Polo's voyage to China in the 14th century opened the door for a flourishing reciprocal trade in goods, including medicinal herbs, between East and West. Eventually, exotic herbs like ginger, cinnamon, and cloves became widely used in European medicine and cooking.

Rebirth of European Scholarship 1000–1400 CE

As European scholars slowly started to absorb the lessons of Arabic medical learning in the early Middle Ages, classical Greek, Roman, and Egyptian texts preserved in the libraries of Constantinople (later Istanbul) filtered back to Europe, and hospitals, medical schools, and universities were founded. Perhaps the most interesting among them was the medical school at Salerno on the west coast of Italy. It not only allowed students from all faiths—Christian, Muslim, and Jewish—to study medicine, but it also allowed women to train as physicians. Trotula, a woman who wrote a book on obstetrics, practiced and taught there in the 12th century CE. Herbs were, of course, central to the healing process. An adage from the Salerno school on sage (*Salvia officinalis*, p. 131) went as follows: *Salvia salvatrix, natura conciliatrix* (sage, the savior; nature, the conciliator).

By the 12th century, trade with Asia and Africa was expanding and new herbs and spices were being regularly imported into Europe. Hildegard of Bingen (1098–1179), the famous German mystic and herbal authority, considered galangal (*Alpinia officinarum*, p. 61)—used in Asia as a warming and nourishing spice for the digestive system—to be the “spice of life,” given by God to provide health and to protect against illness.

Asian Unification

Marco Polo's travels to China in the 14th century coincided with the unification of the whole of Asia from the Yellow Sea in China to the Black Sea in southeastern Europe by Genghis Khan and his grandson Kublai Khan, whose capital was in China, not far from Beijing. Neither the Chinese nor Ayurvedic medical traditions were directly threatened by this conquest. The Mongol rulers were strict in banning the use of certain toxic plants such as aconite (*Aconitum napellus*, p. 160), but their decree may have held an element of self-

preservation, given aconite's alternative use as an arrow poison—one that could have been used against the ruling powers. Moreover, the Mongol unification may have encouraged greater communication between the two medical disciplines.

In other parts of Asia, such as Vietnam and Japan, Chinese culture and medicine exerted the primary influence. While *kampoh*—the traditional herbal medicine of Japan—is distinctive to that country, its roots stem from Chinese practices.

Trade between Continents 1400–1700

Trade routes had slowly expanded during the Middle Ages, bringing exotic new herbs in their wake. From the 15th century onward, an explosion in trade led to a cornucopia of new herbs becoming readily available in Europe. They included plants such as ginger (*Zingiber officinale*, p. 155), cardamom (*Elettaria cardamomum*, p. 93), nutmeg (*Myristica fragrans*, p. 115), turmeric (*Curcuma longa*, p. 90), cinnamon (*Cinnamomum* spp., p. 81), and senna (*Cassia senna*, p. 75).



Manuscript page from an Anglo-Saxon herbal of about 1050 CE, illustrating the aerial parts and root system of a medicinal plant.